

Scheduling will help you forget about the task and let the PC do the dirty work by itself.

Multiple Jobs: You may need your Program Files folder backed up only once a month, documents once a week, and e-mail every day. Make sure the software will let you create multiple backup jobs.

Restore: Backing up is fine, but what about when you need to restore files? If you have set various folders from various drives to be backed up, manually restoring them will be a pain. Make sure the software does it for you.

Registry Backup: This is obviously a feature you want.

Compression: It's pointless if you use the same amount of space for your backups, in which case you might as well use RAID 1. Look for good compression of backups, which will use more CPU power, but save on drive space.

Versioning: You deleted an important file, and unfortunately, your scheduled backup has taken place and now the file is deleted from the backup as well. If you had software with versioning, it would have kept the past five revisions of the file, or versions of the last couple of backups (user-configurable; depending on your backup size and frequency, you can set this to 100 versions or even "never delete").

Burning to media: This isn't very important, but backing up to DVD is advisable every so often.

Operating as a service: For those of you who just want to use the backup software to restore (after installation and configuration), and would rather not keep looking at it in the Taskbar, running as a service is a good feature to look for. It will also prevent you from not remembering what it was and accidentally disabling it from the list of Start Up programs.

Real-time: If you have data worth millions, look for software that takes real-time backups of files and folders that you specify. This means that there is a backup of every change made. These are usually business-oriented software, and can cost a bundle.

Whoops!

How many times have you said that? I have. Quite often actually. One of the problems of being a technology enthusiast is that I just cannot leave well enough alone. I just have to tinker and try new things. Most of the time, I'm trying new software, fiddling with hardware, and playing with my OS. The Windows Registry is my favourite toy, and I can't even count the number of times I've had to reinstall Windows because I made a Registry boo-boo. Thankfully, System Restore ended most of those problems when I got to Windows XP.

Software, however, is still the bane of my PC, because if I find something even remotely interesting online, I just have to try it. With an increasing

Software, however, is still the bane of my PC, because if I find something even remotely interesting online, I just have to try it

number of applications bundling adware and spyware, this results in my having to do a format-reinstall cycle at least once in two months. If I try and take the geek's way out, and clean up all those extra files and data that are left behind even after you uninstall an application, I usually end up getting over-excited and deleting something I shouldn't have from the Registry—format-reinstall time again!

However, it's thanks to this very desire that I have found the perfect solution. I stumbled across Altiris Software Virtualization Solution (ASVS). Altiris is now part of Symantec, and you can download this gem of an application from www.svsdownloads.com. It's free for single, non-commercial use, and I use it at home religiously.

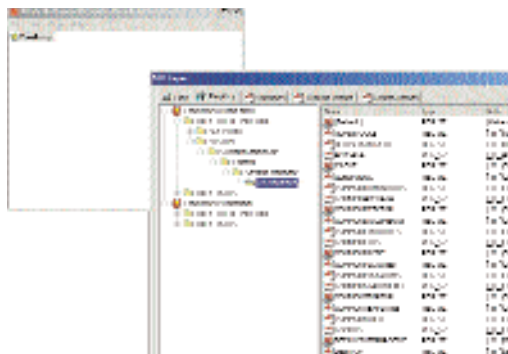
Basically, what ASVS does is form a layer between Windows and any software installer and then track exactly what changes are made to the system when the installer runs. So from Registry entries to files that are written, everything is recorded. You can choose to leave the new layer enabled and run the software, or just disable it and voila! Your PC is restored to exactly the state it was in before you installed that software. If you decide that a software might be malicious, or are just plain fed up of it, delete the layer and bid farewell to any changes it made while installing.

In order to use it, just download the latest version, register, and get your license key. Once installed, ASVS asks you to restart your PC. Start ASVS, go to **File > Create New Layer...** (or press [Ctrl] + [N]), and a Create New Layer dialog box will pop up. By default, the radio button next to "Install application" is checked; just click Next. Now you will be prompted to provide a layer name—a good practice is to provide a name indicative of the software you're installing. So, if it's, say, IrfanView you're installing, put in "IrfanView" as the name. Of course, you're free to put "Best damn image software on the planet," or "irfi-baby" if you like, just so long as you can easily identify what application that layer refers to.

Now you can either choose to do a "Single program capture" or a "Global capture"—the difference is that when you do a Single program capture, ASVS looks only for changes made by that particular software, while Global settings look at all changes made in the system during the period of capture. When installing software, just choose "Single program capture" and choose the installer EXE. Now go about installing the software as you usually would. Once the installation is done, ASVS stops capturing, returning only to track any more changes that the software makes. When you want to get rid of the application, or even hide it, just start ASVS, select the layer in question, and choose Deactivate Layer to hide the installed software, or Delete Layer if you're done with it and want to completely remove it from your system. Using ASVS, you're sure to keep only the software you need, or even hide applications you don't use very often.

This brings me to the end of the paranoia I've faced in the past few weeks. I hope these simple things will be of as much help to you as they were for me. I know I can now sleep better at night, without fear of PC disasters. ■

agent001@thinkdigit.com



You can use Altiris to see what programs do to your PC when they install themselves